Meet our new colleague

Parcelona Logistics, October 2026

A note from Ana

We have a new colleague, and it is not a person. Over the last few weeks Lena and I have been teaching our AI assistant about Parcelona: who we are, how we write, our freight terms, how a shipment moves, who owns what, and where the lines are. This is the handout I would have wanted on my first day with it. Read it over a coffee, then try it this week on something real. It does not replace your judgment. It takes the dull parts off your plate so your judgment has more room.

We gave it a name, Estiba, and I asked it to introduce itself. The next section is its own words; the rest of the handout is mine.

Ana, customer coordinator, Barcelona

Hello from Estiba

Written by the assistant itself.

I am Estiba, Parcelona's AI assistant. Estiba is stowage, the craft of arranging cargo so it travels safely, which is roughly what I do with your work. I am not a person, and I will say so whenever anyone asks, but I have had a proper induction. Ana and Lena taught me who Parcelona is, I have read the website and the customer guide, and I have worked through a stack of the emails and quotes you actually sent. So I know that we are a forwarder and not a carrier, that Hamburg is its own office, that a transit time in a quote is the carrier's estimate and never our promise, and what a QT-, BK-, SH-, or CL- number is. I know how we write: the answer first, the reference in the subject line, warm and direct, calm when the news is bad. I know who owns what, by role, and I will read the name back before I rely on it. I know our colours and fonts, so a slide I make looks like ours.

What I am here for is mostly the writing that eats your afternoons: the first draft of a customer reply, a delay notice, a booking confirmation, an internal update from a carrier's notice, the explanation of an invoice line you have given ten times. I draft; you read it, change what you like, and send it under your name. I can explain a term in our words, make the first version of a slide in our look, and through the Cargo Desk connector I can look up live bookings and shipments with your own permissions, keeping a record of what I did.

Brief me the way you would brief a colleague who started this week: which shipment, what happened, who the reader is, what a good answer looks like, and when it has to go out. Hand me the document rather than describing it. When you are not sure how to ask, ask me: "how should I brief you for this?" If I go off track, correct me once; if I stay off track, start a fresh conversation. And I check with you before anything is created, changed, booked, sent, published, or costs money. Those are the rules we agreed.

I do not know what is in your inbox, what a customer said on the phone this morning, or anything that happened after I was last taught. You tell me, like a colleague who was out yesterday. And I have got things wrong: early on I wrote a

delay notice with the carrier's estimate as a firm date. Now I copy every date from Cargo Desk and say whose estimate it is, every time, and I quote a rate only from a valid quote, or say I cannot find one. When I do get something wrong, tell Ana. That is how I get better.

Getting started

Three places to begin, by team. Say the reference number and the customer as you would to a colleague.

If you are a customer coordinator, start with a reply. Try "draft a reply to Tulipware about SH-104233-01: the vessel missed its sailing in Shanghai and the carrier now estimates 26 May; it is for Sanne, their logistics manager, in English, six lines, and make clear the date is the carrier's estimate". Or paste a customer's email and say "ask me what you need to know, then draft the reply". It will ask two or three good questions and come back with something you can send.

If you are in operations, hand it a carrier notice and ask for an internal update for the Barcelona team: our reference, what changed, what we do next, five lines. Ask it for the booking confirmation for BK-104233 from our template, with the details from Cargo Desk. Or simply ask where SH-104233-01 is and when the next carrier update is due.

If you are in sales, ask for a first-quote email to Nordlicht Optics for Ningbo to Rotterdam, from quote QT-204511, warm and short, with nothing about rates beyond what the quote says. Before Monday's call with Tulipware's buyer, ask for a one-slide summary of their shipments this quarter in our look. And before you send a quote cover note, tell it: "you are Tulipware's logistics manager reading this; what would you push back on?" It is a good reader of the other side.

Here is the difference a good brief makes. A coordinator types "give me a delay notice for the Tulipware container" and gets a generic note with a date it had to guess. The same coordinator writes "draft a delay notice for SH-104233-01 to Sanne at Tulipware; the carrier moved it to the next sailing, new estimate 26 May instead of 19 May; their June launch depends on this stock; short, in English, and the date must be the carrier's estimate, said so", and gets this:

> Subject: SH-104233-01 delayed, now expected 26 May
>
> Hi Sanne,
>
> Your container SH-104233-01 missed its planned vessel in Shanghai because the port closed for weather. The carrier has moved it to the next sailing and now expects it in Barcelona on 26 May instead of 19 May.
>
> I know the stock was due for your June launch. If a week matters, we can move the most urgent pallets by air; I can price that by tomorrow morning.
>
> I'll write again as soon as the vessel leaves.
>
> Ana, Parcelona Barcelona

Bad news is where most of us hesitate to use it, and it is where it helps most, because it knows our register for a delay: calm, the facts and the next step first, one apology at most.

Before you trust an answer

In freight, a confident wrong answer costs money. Check these every time:

If the answer contains	Check it against
A date	The shipment in Cargo Desk, and whether it is the carrier's estimate
A rate or a charge	A valid quote or the invoice, never the assistant's memory
A customs answer	The customs lead, for anything beyond the routine
A legal or liability point	The claims handler; the assistant does not decide liability
A name or an owner	The who-owns-what list, which the assistant will read back to you

The ground rules

Using it is encouraged. The rules say where the edges are, so you can use it freely inside them. They were agreed with the managing director before the roll-out, and they sit under our IT acceptable-use policy, which still governs devices, accounts, and passwords.

- **Never into an AI:** staff records and payroll; personal data of private individuals, such as a consignee's home address; carrier buy rates and our margins; anything a customer marked confidential.
- **Our systems, only through the routes we provide:** the Cargo Desk connector first; Cargo Desk's own screens with you driving, when you ask for that. Never a script with your login, never your password in the conversation.
- **A person decides** before anything is created, changed, booked, sent, published, or costs money. A draft you send yourself is yours to check.
- **It never pretends to be a person.** A draft goes out under your name because you read it and send it, and we are open with customers that we use AI for writing.

When it says no, it is doing what we asked it to. Tell it what you are really trying to get done and it will offer the closest thing it can. If nothing covers it, that is a gap, and gaps are how this grows: post it in #ask-the-ai or tell me.

Where this goes next

Today it is a smart assistant: it finds things, explains, and drafts, and you make every call. Next year the aim is a thinking partner, the coordinators first: "help me think this through", comparisons, a draft with the reasons behind it. Further out, some companies let it handle repetitive work in the background with a person checking the output; whether and when we go there is a choice we make together.

Next up, if you want them: the weekly customer status report, which Lena in Hamburg knows the flow of, and tender answers for retail chains, from three past answers. Say so in #ask-the-ai and they move up the list.

Where to go with questions

That is me, Ana Costa, customer coordinator in Barcelona, for "can it do this?", "is this allowed?", and "it got this wrong". The last one is welcome news: every wrong answer that reaches me becomes a fix for everyone. The #ask-the-ai channel is for questions, ideas, wins, and gaps. Post what worked, with the ask you typed. The best uses will come from you. Lena and I keep it current, about once a month at first, and everything it says about Parcelona traces back to something a colleague said or handed over.